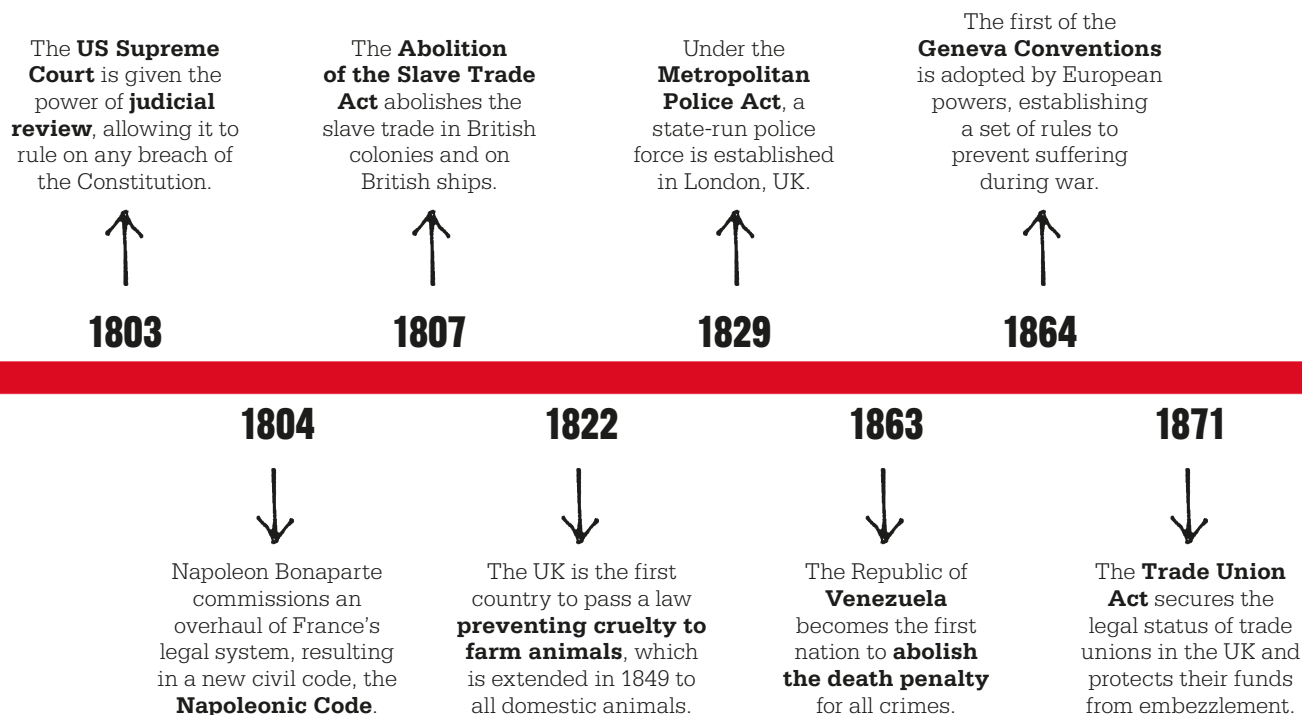




The spirit of the Age of Reason of the 18th century led to fundamental changes in how society was organized: the French and American revolutions overthrew the old established order, and new nation-states were created, with laws and constitutions that upheld the values of democracy, liberty, and human rights. Through the 19th century, more and more countries adopted similar models of government, espousing the same values. But a key factor involved in the changes within society was the Industrial Revolution, which started in 18th-century Britain and went on to shape the modern world.

With industrialization came capitalism, and while political power had been transferred from monarchies and aristocracies to parliaments, the owners of the new

industries held the economic reins. The rural peasant class shrank, to be replaced with a class of city-dwelling factory workers, no longer in thrall to landowners but instead reliant on industrialists for their livelihood.

Changing societies

The governments and laws of the new era's nation-states had to evolve to reflect the changing nature of the societies within them, recognizing the rights of all their citizens. There was a gradual move toward more liberal legislation, protecting the interests of workers and consumers, as well as ensuring that businesses could continue to bring prosperity in a fair market economy.

Fresh from revolution, the US and France were among the first to rise to the challenge of creating legal systems fit for the modern world.

The principle of citizens' rights was written into the US Constitution, but further legislation was needed to protect the people from abuses of power. A major step was to grant the Supreme Court the power of judicial review so it could exercise the necessary checks and balances on other branches of government. At much the same time, France began to draw up its new civil code, which became a model for many other nations' civil codes.

British parliamentary and legal systems were well established and evolved more slowly to the demands of industrialized society. But with the formation of the Metropolitan Police Force by an Act of Parliament, the UK created a policing model fit for modern cities, with uniformed officers under a central command given powers to enforce the law.